

CCTV Converter

User Guide

Version 2.0 • Windows 10 & 11

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davidarthur.app/cctvconverter

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1. Welcome

CCTV Converter turns the proprietary recordings produced by Chinese DVRs into standard MP4 files you can play, edit and share anywhere — and gives you the tools to review, enhance, redact and pull highlights from that footage, all on your own PC.

It works **entirely offline**: your footage is read, converted and written locally and never leaves your machine. There are no accounts, no ads and no tracking.

This guide covers everything from a first conversion to the built-in editor, privacy redaction (faces, number plates or any area), the multi-camera sync view, the continuous day timeline, and automatic motion highlights. Use the clickable Contents page (or your PDF reader's bookmarks panel) to jump to any section.

2. Installation & First Run

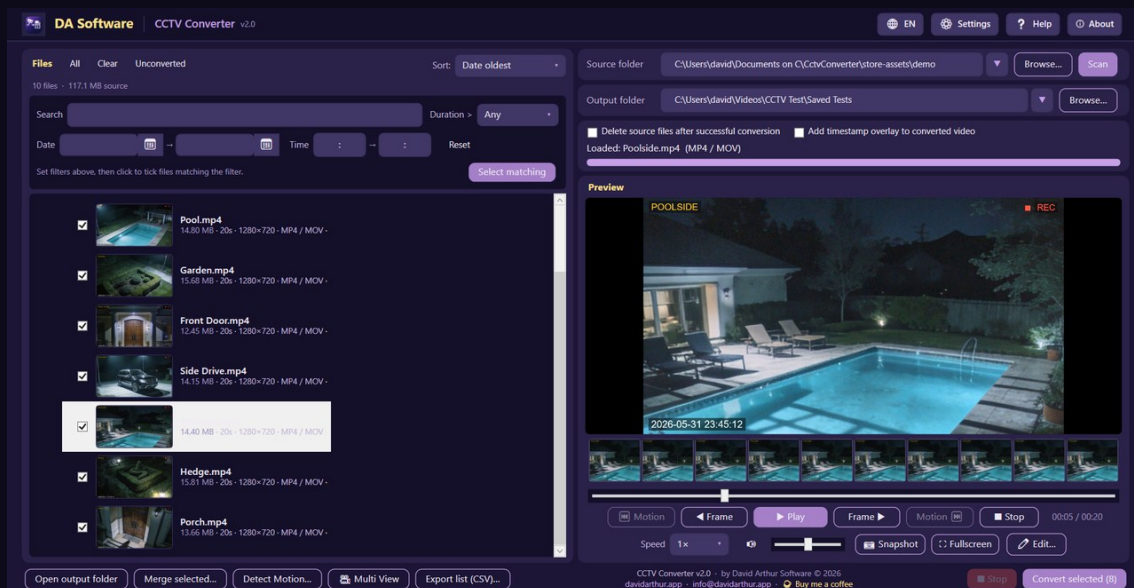
- **Microsoft Store (recommended)** — one-click install, automatic updates, signed by Microsoft. Get it at apps.microsoft.com or from davidarthur.app/cctvconverter.
- **Direct download** — a self-contained installer is also available from the website for offline PCs.

The Store version is self-contained: it bundles everything it needs (including its video engine), so there are no prerequisites to install and no administrator rights are required for normal use.

On first launch the interface appears in your Windows display language where supported (16 languages are available); you can change it any time from the globe icon in the toolbar.

3. The Main Window

The window is split into three areas: a **file list** on the left (your source folders and the videos inside them), a **preview** on the right, and an **action bar** along the bottom.



The main window: source list and filters on the left, live preview on the right.

Choosing a source and output

- **Source folder** — drag a folder (or your DVR's SD card) onto the window, or click Browse. The app walks any date subfolders and lists every video file it finds.
- **Output folder** — where converted MP4s are written. Both folders are remembered for next time.

Finding the clips you want

- Filter by minimum duration, by date, by time of day, or by filename.
- Folders with no matching clips collapse out of the way automatically.
- Tick individual files, or use **Select matching** to tick everything that passes the current filter.

4. Converting Footage

Tick the files you want and click **Convert selected**. Where the source is already MP4-compatible the app does a *stream copy* — the video is repackaged without being re-encoded, so it is instant and bit-identical in quality. Otherwise it re-encodes to clean H.264.

- **Parallel conversion** — convert up to 8 files at once (set in Settings). A full day of clips finishes in seconds.
- **Encoder** — Auto, CPU, or a specific GPU (NVIDIA / Intel / AMD). Auto picks the best available and falls back to CPU automatically if a GPU encode fails.
- **Date/time burn-in** — tick “Add timestamp overlay” to burn a per-frame clock into the bottom-left of the output, taken from each file's recording time.
- **Merge** — combine a day's clips, or any selection, into one continuous MP4 in chronological order.
- **CSV export** — export the file list (name, size, duration, resolution, format, timestamps).
- **Optional cleanup** — “Delete source files after successful conversion” reclaims space as you go, with confirmation.

***Tip:** Conversions are cancellable at any point, and partly-written files are cleaned up automatically, so nothing is left in a bad state.*

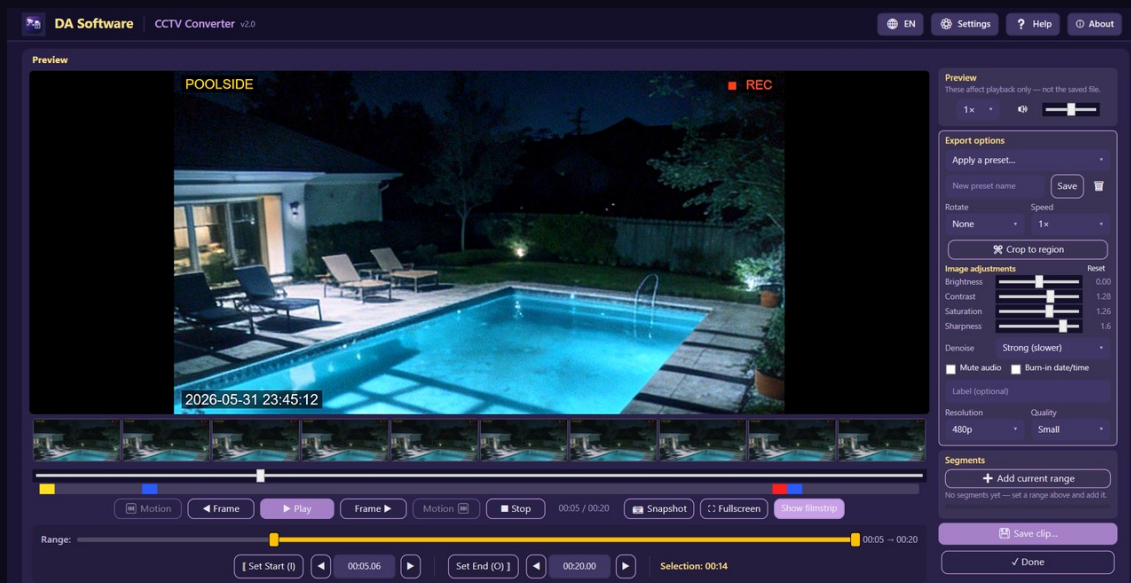
5. Reviewing & Preview

Select any clip to load it into the preview. Play and pause, step frame by frame, change the playback speed (0.5×–8×), adjust volume, and go fullscreen with draggable on-screen controls.

- **Filmstrip** — a strip of thumbnails above the seek bar lets you scrub by sight; hovering the bar shows a preview pop-up.
- **Motion heatmap** — after a motion scan, a coloured heatmap along the seek bar shows where the action is; jump straight between events with the prev/next-motion buttons.
- **Snapshots** — capture any frame as a JPEG or PNG, or copy it straight to the clipboard.

6. The Built-in Editor

Select a converted clip and click **Edit** to open the in-place editor. Edits always export to a new MP4 — your original files are never modified — and a progress bar with a cancel button shows the export as it runs.



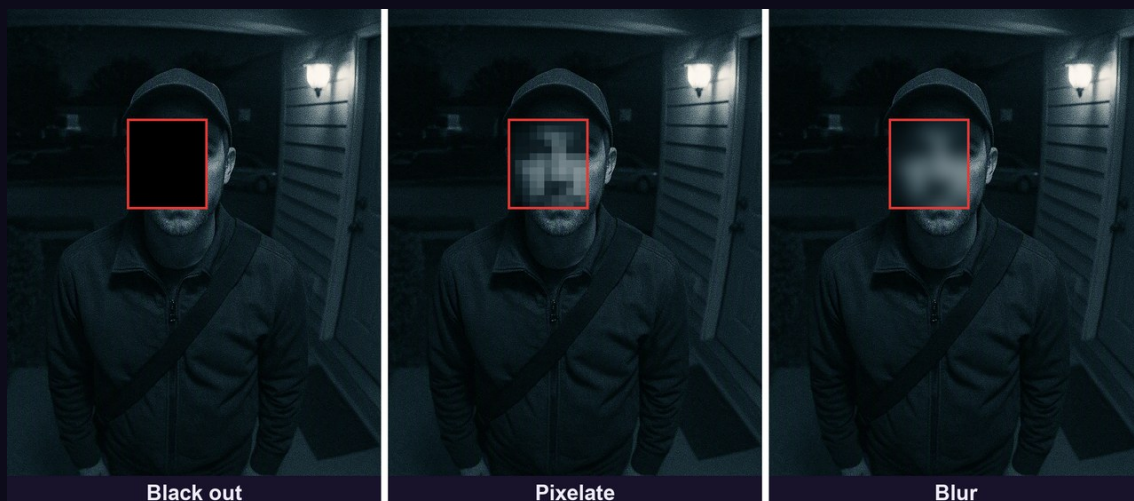
The editor: trim, crop, rotate, image adjustments, noise reduction, output size and presets.

- **Trim** — set the start and end points (down to a single frame) with the range slider or the I / O keyboard shortcuts; mark multiple segments to export separately or merged.
- **Crop & rotate** — crop to a region of interest or rotate footage recorded sideways.
- **Image adjustments** — brightness, contrast, saturation, sharpness and gamma, all with a live preview.
- **One-tap looks** — instant presets (Night, Bright, Clarify, Vivid, Black & White), each shown as a thumbnail so you can preview the effect before applying it.
- **Noise reduction** — Off / Light / Medium / Strong, to clean up grainy night footage.
- **Output size & quality** — choose a resolution and quality level for the exported file.
- **Presets** — save a combination of edit settings and reapply it to other clips in one click.

7. Privacy — Hide Faces, Plates & Areas

The editor can hide faces, number plates and any other sensitive detail before you share a clip — useful when handing footage to a neighbour, an insurer or the public. Everything runs on your own PC; nothing is uploaded.

- **Detect faces** — automatically finds faces and follows each one as it moves through the clip, drawing a box that tracks it frame by frame.
- **Choose who to hide** — click a box to keep that person visible or to hide them; only the faces you pick are redacted.
- **Black out, pixelate or blur** — choose how hidden areas look: a solid black box, a coarse mosaic, or a soft blur. The Box size slider grows every automatic box to cover hair or a full head.



The three redaction styles applied to the same face. Pixelate and blur leave the scene readable while making the person unidentifiable.

Hide and track anything else

Faces aren't the only thing worth hiding. Turn on **Hide areas manually** and drag a box over anything — a number plate, a bystander, a screen, a document. A drawn box covers that spot for the whole clip. If the subject moves, click **Track this area** and the app follows it automatically: the box glides with the subject in the preview and in the export.

- **Draw where it's clearest** — tracking starts from the exact pixels inside your box, so draw it where the subject is big, sharp and fully visible.
- **Check the reported span** — after tracking, the app shows which part of the clip is covered (for example 0:00 to 0:27). A track ends when its subject leaves the frame or is hidden for more than a few seconds.
- **Cover other appearances** — if the subject shows up again later in the clip, draw another box there and track again; you can combine as many tracked and static boxes as you need.



Track this area: the box stays locked on the vehicle as it moves through the frame — no manual keyframing.

Tip: Automatic detection and tracking are a helpful first pass, not a guarantee — always play the clip back and cover anything left exposed with a manual box before sharing.

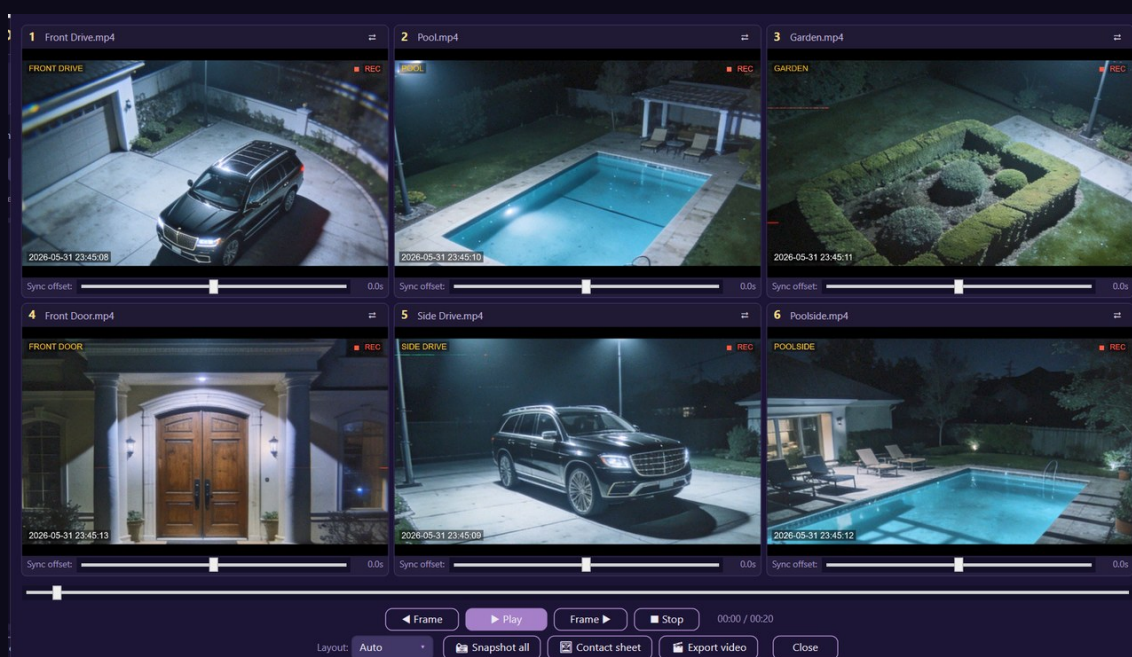
8. Sharing & Exporting

Beyond a straight MP4, the editor's **Export** menu offers ways to share a clip that fit how it will be used.

- **Compress for email** — re-encode to a small target size so a clip fits an email or messaging-app limit.
- **Animated GIF** — turn a short moment into a looping GIF for a quick preview or a report.
- **Evidence report** — generate a printable PDF that records the source file details and SHA-256 checksums, for a chain-of-custody trail.
- **Deinterlace** — smooth the combing produced by older analogue cameras.
- **Watermark / case number** — burn a line of text (for example a case reference) into the exported copy.

9. Multi-Camera View

Tick two or more converted clips and click **Multi View** to play up to six cameras side by side on a single shared timeline.



Multi-camera view: up to six cameras on one timeline with per-camera sync offsets.

- Nudge each camera's **sync offset** to line up clocks that have drifted apart.
- Rename and rearrange cells, and solo a cell to hear its audio.
- **Snapshot all** cameras at once, or build a combined **contact sheet**.
- **Export a synchronized composite** video of the whole grid.

10. Continuous Timeline

DVRs chop a day into many short files. Right-click a day and choose **Play as timeline** to watch them as one seamless recording instead of opening each file in turn.

- **One scrubber for the whole day** — drag across the joins between files without a gap.
- **Jump between motion events** across the entire span, even across file boundaries.
- **Export any span** — set an in and out point anywhere on the day and export just that stretch, trimmed and joined for you.

11. Motion Highlights

Select footage and choose **Detect motion** to have the app scan for movement and extract only the clips where something happens — turning hours of recording into a short reel of events.

- **Sensitivity** — Low / Medium / High controls how much movement counts as an event.
- **Pre/post-roll** — keep a few seconds before and after each event so nothing is clipped.
- **Output** — save each event as its own file, or stitch them all into a single highlight reel.
- **Review** — optionally review and deselect false positives before anything is written.
- **Inside the editor** — click Detect motion within the editor to mark active stretches as segments, then step between them with the prev/next-motion buttons.

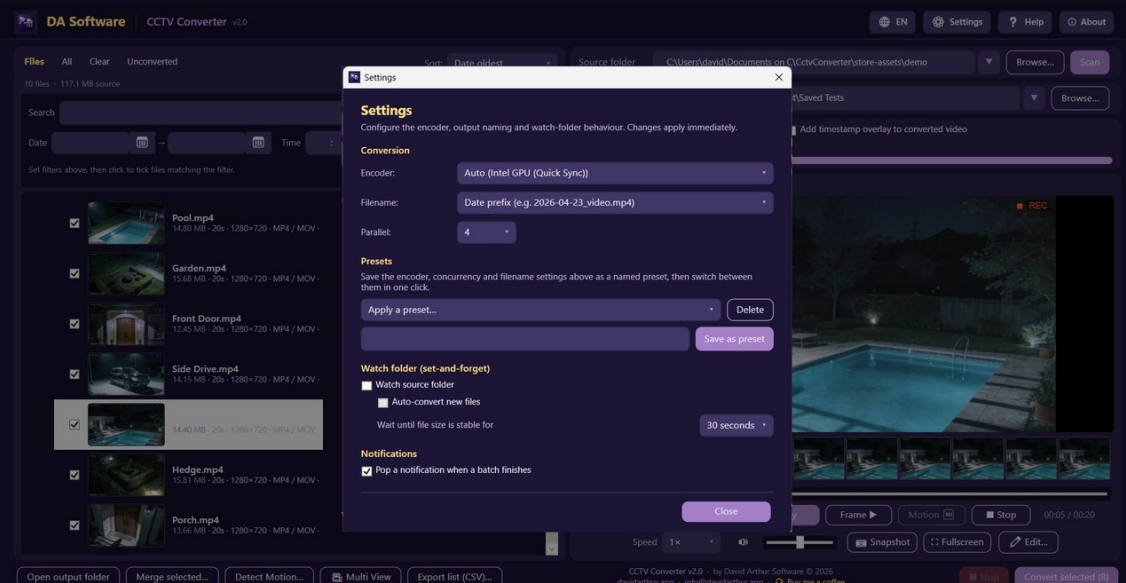
Tip: Motion results are cached, so changing the pre/post-roll and re-exporting does not repeat the scan.

12. Watch-Folder Mode

Turn on **Watch source folder** in Settings and the app monitors that folder, automatically converting new recordings as they appear — a hands-off workflow for an always-on DVR. It waits until each file has finished being written before converting, and can pop a notification when a batch completes.

13. Settings

Open **Settings** from the toolbar to configure conversion and automation. Changes apply immediately.



Settings: encoder, output naming, presets, watch-folder and notifications.

- **Encoder** — Auto, CPU, or a specific GPU.
- **Filename** — how output files are named (original name, or with a date prefix/suffix).
- **Parallel** — how many files convert at once (1–8).
- **Presets** — save the encoder, concurrency and naming settings as a named preset.
- **Watch folder** — auto-convert new files, with a file-stability delay.
- **Notifications** — pop a notification when a batch finishes.

14. Keyboard Shortcuts

Space	Play / pause the preview
Left / Right	Step one frame back / forward
I / O	Set the start (in) / end (out) point in the editor
F	Fullscreen preview
M	Mute / unmute
Esc	Exit fullscreen, or exit the editor

15. Troubleshooting

A file is flagged “can't convert”

A few formats are genuinely undecodable by any third-party tool — most notably Hikvision encrypted backups (.crypt), which need Hikvision's own player. Standard Hikvision H.264 backups convert fine.

A file won't convert because it's “in use”

Another program (Windows' Films & TV, an Explorer preview, or antivirus) may be holding the file. Close any preview windows and try again; the app retries automatically for a few seconds.

The preview won't play a source file

Some raw CCTV formats can't be previewed until converted. Convert the file first, then preview or edit the MP4.

Where are my settings and logs?

Open *About* → *Open log/data folder*, or browse to %LOCALAPPDATA%\CctvConverter\. It holds your config, the thumbnail cache and an error log — useful if you ever need to send a support report.

16. Privacy & Licensing

- **Offline** — your footage is processed locally and never uploaded.
- **No accounts, no tracking, no ads.** The only optional network use is checking for an update when you ask it to.
- **Local data** — only your folder paths, preferences and caches are stored, under %LOCALAPPDATA%\CctvConverter\.

CCTV Converter uses the open-source **ffmpeg** project (under the GPL) for video processing; the licence and source details ship with the app. The full Privacy Policy and Terms are at davidarthur.app/cctvconverter/privacy/ and davidarthur.app/terms/.

Tip: *Converted, edited or timestamped output should not be relied upon as the sole forensic or legal record — always retain and verify the original source files for insurance, legal or law-enforcement use.*

17. Support & Updates

The Microsoft Store edition updates automatically; you can also choose *About* → *Check for updates* at any time. For help, email info@davidarthur.app or see the online guide and FAQ at davidarthur.app/cctvconverter/help/ and davidarthur.app/cctvconverter/faq/.

